various MEA annual reports after 2002 underline India's conciliatory approach. Bilateral relations between the two countries attained new levels of intensity and cooperation by 2004, based on regular political and economic interactions.[54] By 2005, the bloodiest year in Afghanistan since the ouster of the Taliban, Manmohan Singh and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi visited Kabul and stayed overnight at Karzai's request, displaying solidarity with the new government.[55] With the Afghan Taliban having launched an insurgency against the ISAF and Afghan forces, the security situation in Kabul had become increasingly precarious. Worried about repeated attacks by the Taliban and the Hizb-e-Islami (which supported the Kabul government but was opposed to Western forces) with support from Pakistan, India saw reason in strengthening ties with Karzai.[56] In November 2006 Shivshankar Menon, then India's foreign secretary, a staunch conciliator who later became national security advisor (2010–14), categorically informed the US under secretary of defence, Eric Edelman, that New Delhi was dedicated to 'empowering Karzai' and will strengthen him politically and economically.[57]

India's tilt towards Karzai was supplemented by the fragmentation of the UF. Riddled with rifts since its inception, the UF could not withstand the changes at Bonn. The UF's disintegration complicated India's relations with its various leaders. Dostum was viewed as an opportunist (by Indian policymakers) who could not be trusted with long-term partnerships, whereas the Massoud brothers (Ahmad Zia and Ahmad Wali Massoud) had lost political weight even if they were to be engaged with. Ismael Khan in Herat and the Hazara Shia groups including that of Mohaqiq and Karim Khalili engaged with India but looked for guidance from Tehran, limiting New Delhi's room for strategic maneuver. Qanooni and Abdullah on the other hand were heavyweights and had tremendous support from India, but were unable to come to power given Karzai's political value within and outside Afghanistan, and his manipulative capabilities in order to survive. As a member of the National Security Advisory Board (NSAB) put it, 'basically the game was to look for Pashtuns who would be friendly and interested in working with India'.[58]

Karzai's snubbing of former UF leaders had not gone unnoticed by top Indian leadership. PM Manmohan Singh had personally asked Karzai to 'avoid isolating'